

ZHAU

Stars: Yellow / White / Blue Dwarf

Known for: Home of the Honor Guard (nomads), Lance Station, Strange Portal Builder Remnants

Exports: Hydrogen, Crude Metals, Archaeological Findings

Imports: Medicine, Technology

The trinary system Zhai is often called the rogue state of the Quadrant of the Pillar. The abundance of habitable planets has provided a home to many settlers from the Quadrant – and lately – from all across the Horizon.

BRIBES AND HONOR

For a very long time, Zhai lacked a central government. That changed when a group of nomad leaders decided that it's time to build a central nomad base at the beginning of the Second Portal War. They proclaimed themselves the Akbars of Lance Station and seized control of the portals in Zhai. The nomads stationed here call themselves "The Honor Guard". Some nomads used a hidden portal into the Fourth Horizon in search for support (or cowardly fled to a safe space to hide if you ask a Zenithian). Others stayed and started producing weapons and ships to defend the Horizon.

Since their take-over, the market for mineral claims has been busted open; anyone can buy a claim in the Zhai system for a set percentage of their yearly yield. These lucrative contracts, usually handled by middle men, have resulted in a trade boom for Lance Station and its bazaar.

But everything is not as idyllic as it seems, and there are rumors about settlements and mining stations thinking about a revolt against the ever thinning nomad population in the system.

THE ZHAU SYSTEM

Zhai is a trinary star system so sparsely populated that it rarely confers names on its celestial bodies. Instead, the names of celestial bodies are based on the position of the object relative to the system's star. At first glance, several of the planets in the Zhai system seem to be prime candidates for human habitation. However, some of them have turned out to be highly unstable and prone to extensive natural disasters. In the wake of these catastrophes, worn settlers have found traces of the Portal Builder civilization – a discovery that has spurred a second wave of colonizers coming from all corners of the Horizon. The worlds orbiting Zhai-B are undergoing rapid growth with a multitude of new colonies. The distant Zhai-C star is shrouded in mystery, and is often used by parents of the Quadrant to frighten their children. Of the many expeditions that have travelled there, few have returned – but those that do speak of marvelous things. The wildest rumours speak of hidden portals to other worlds in the Third Horizon or beyond.

REMNANTS OF THE PORTAL BUILDERS

Explorers have recently found several ancient artifacts and temple-like constructions in the Zhai system. Many believe that these are Portal Builder in origin, and a few scientists go so far as to claim that the abundance of habitable planets in the system indicates that this once was a core system of the Portal Builder civilization. These discoveries have turned the system into a ripe target for archaeologists and looters.

LANCE STATION

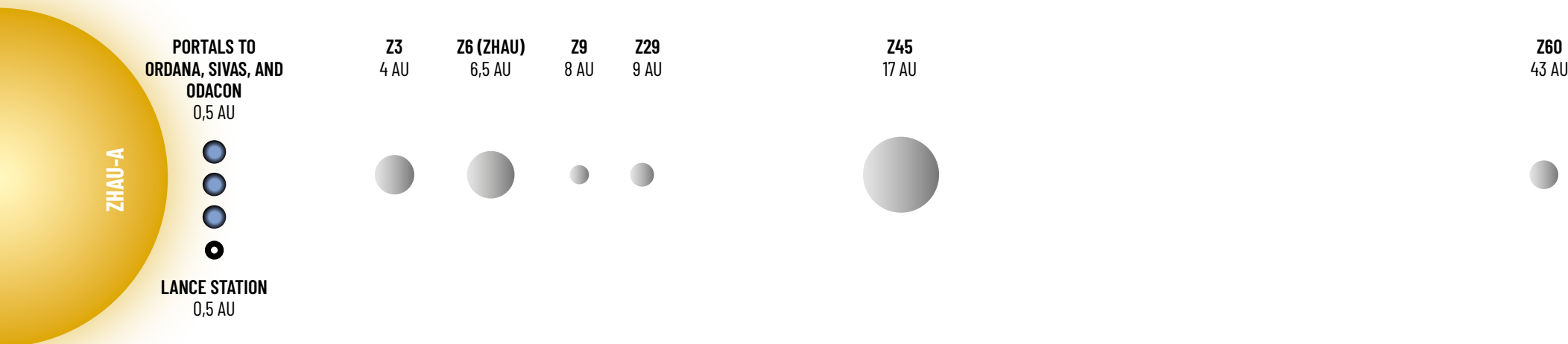
Lance Station is a portal station that controls all traffic going in and out of the Zhai system. The nomads equipped it with enough firepower to make anyone think twice about trying to take it from them, and set up a free trading zone that has become the Zhai system's primary marketplace. The Honor Guard takes a percentage of each trade and enjoys a good life as the system's leaders. The station is also home to the Claims Office, where prospectors can register their strikes in the Zhai system and receive the protection of the Honor Guard – again, provided they hand over a percentage of the earnings from their claims.

Population: 600 residents, capacity for 3.000 visitors.

Governance: Ruled by a council of nomad moguls, led by mogul Ikram Hassan.

Law & order: The station is protected by a force of Honor Guards.

Gravity: 1G



ZHAU-B
80 AU FROM ZHAU-A

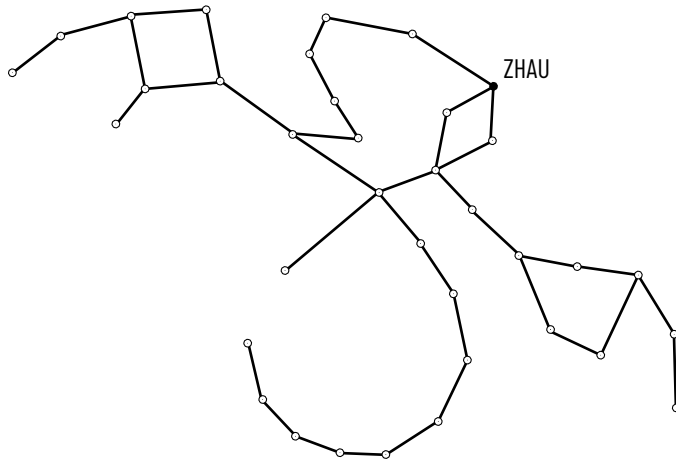
ZB3
4 AU

ZB4 (ZORANA)
6 AU

ZB7
15 AU

ZB10 (YIBAE)
22 AU

ZB46
32 AU



ZHAU-A OVERVIEW

Lance Station: Forward base of the Honor Guard.

Z-3: The Mharatta Shipyard.

Z-6 (ZHAU): Main planet of the system, home to several colonies.

Z-9: Akenatohna Space Port.

Z-29: Tropical Planet known for its great ocean.

Z-45: Several "shadow colonies" were nuked into oblivion here.

Z-60: Metal-rich planet with tightly controlled mining operations.

ZHAU-B OVERVIEW

ZB-3: Yah-Zhau Frontier Station with mobile mining refineries.

ZB-4 (Zorana): The Carbon Sultanate.

ZB-7: Stone planet with large aluminum deposits.

ZB-10 (Yivae): Named after the sect of Warrior Nuns residing here.

ZB-46: Small frontier colonies in a cooperative community.

ZHAU-C OVERVIEW

ZC-4: Remains from the Portal Builders have been found here, rumored to be monitored by Draconites.

ASTEROID BELT: Microsun phenomenon appearing at regular intervals.

ZC-X: Rumored to contain a portal to the Fourth Horizon.

SETTLERS AND PROSPECTORS

Each of Zhau's three stars have habitable worlds that have seen an influx of new colonists thanks to the corsair pacification efforts of the Honor Legion. The newcomers come from all corners of the Horizon and range from refugees looking for a safe haven to prospectors looking to strike big. Few manage to survive the harsh realities of the system.

The price for colonization is high. The Honor Guard demands tribute for its protection, and if the tithe cannot be paid in birr or commodities, the moguls do not hesitate to take land and claim. It is strictly forbidden to establish so-called "shadow colonies" in the system, and any illegal intrusions are swiftly dealt with to prevent others from trying. The bombing of some "shadow colonies" led to political sanctions against the Honor Guard, issued by the Alabaster Council.

ZC4
5 AU

ASTEROID BELT
12 AU

ZCX
21 AU

ZHAU-C
400 AU FROM ZHAU-A